Leadership Tool: Running Effective Meetings in a Hybrid Work Environment

Often leaders treat meetings as an everyday occurrence, spending little time thinking about how to get the most out of the time spent. However, in a study by Perlow et. al (2017), the researchers surveyed 182 senior managers, in a range of industries, and found:

- 65% said meetings keep them from completing their own work.
- 71% said meetings are unproductive and inefficient.
- 64% said meetings come at the expense of deep thinking.
- 62% said meetings miss opportunities to bring the team closer together.

The traditional meeting paradigm has changed over the past few years in the contemporary landscape of work, especially as companies move to a hybrid model. In a context where the harmonization of both the digital and physical space is paramount, learning necessitates a nuanced understanding of how to run hybrid meetings most effectively. Best practices are crucial to ensure both seamless integration of diverse communication platforms and also to foster an inclusive, engaging, and productive meeting environment. The effectiveness of hybrid meetings hinges on a leader's ability to adapt and ensure that all participants are afforded opportunities to contribute, collaborate, and connect irrespective of their physical location.

A sign of both an effective leader and a forward-thinking organization is the ability to adopt best practices in a new environment, like hybrid meetings. By leading the way, utilizing these best practices, the leader demonstrates a commitment to maximizing the collective intelligence (and potential) of their team while acknowledging and bridging the inherent challenges (and opportunities) of hybrid blended interaction. At its core, effective hybrid meetings are important in cultivating a sense of community, ensuring clarity of communication, and advancing shared goals. Overall, embracing best practices when running a hybrid meeting is not only an operational necessity but a strategic imperative that can significantly influence team cohesion and overall success in a rapidly evolving work environment.

Running an Effective Meeting

Effectively running a hybrid meeting requires understanding both traditional face-to-face meeting best practices and best practices strategies for engaging in a digital environment. When hybrid meetings are well executed, they can be a catalyst for both productivity and connection.

While some best practices are universal across both formats, certain strategies are particularly relevant in the context of in-person or online participants. This article looks to discuss both the universal and hybrid specific best practices to ensure leaders run effective hybrid meetings. By implementing these best practices, leaders are more likely to run hybrid meetings that maximize the effectiveness of these synchronous, goal-driven efforts.

Pre-Meeting Best Practices

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #1: Define the Meetings Purpose

The first best practice is both a simple one and one that is often overlooked in all contexts of meetings. Defining the purpose of the meeting is an essential step to determine if a meeting is necessary. Too often we have meetings, just to have meetings. Just take a second and think about all the reoccurring meetings on your schedule. While reoccurring meetings are not inherently a time waster, it depends on how often the leader determines if the meeting is still necessary. A review of a meeting's purpose is important for every meeting you are asking people to attend. While an effectively run meeting that has a purpose can have a significant impact on both relationship building and productivity, a meeting that has no purpose can have the opposite effect.

So, when should we have hybrid meetings? A general rule of thumb is, when the communication is one-way directed (like a leader giving updates) then a meeting is not necessary and another platform of communication is likely to be more effective (email, phone call, etc.). However, if the communication is two-way, meaning feedback and information flows from both the leader and team members, a meeting is a valuable way to go. Meetings where decisions need to be made, real time communication between multiple parties needs to occur, problems need to be discussed, or work tasks need collaborative planning, are all good reasons to bring people together. In general, it is those work-related activities where multiple people need to communicate and/or provide feedback. On the other hand, if a leader is just providing an update, getting slackers on track, or trying to encourage enthusiasm, these are not an effective use of everyone's time and often lead to individuals becoming disengage or even skipping meetings.

Three questions you can ask yourself, to ensure as a leader you are calling a beneficial meeting are:

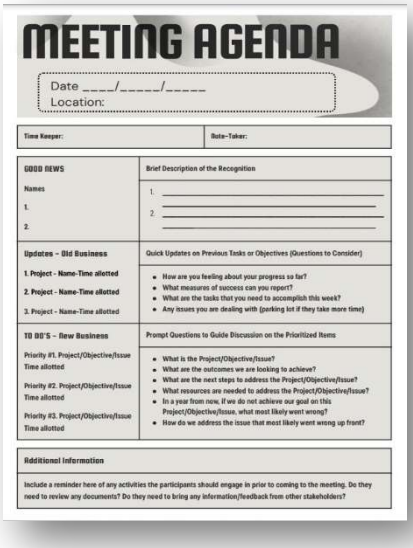
- *What specific outcomes do we need to achieve by the end of the meeting?* This question looks to identify clear, actionable goals for the meeting. It prompts the leader to determine what the outcome of the meeting looks like and then they can work their way back from that point on the agenda. Are there decisions that need to be made? Are there problems that need to be solved? What ideas need to be generated? By thinking about this overall question (and these more specific questions) leaders can ensure the meeting has a focused agenda that is directly aligned with the team or organizational goals. Additionally, this clarity will help determine the structure of the meeting, who needs to be involved (selecting people to invite to the meeting) and determining how the participants can contribute effectively.
- *Could the meeting's objectives be accomplished through other means?* As suggested above, often meetings are scheduled out of habit or tradition rather than necessity. Ask yourself if an

email, a shared document, a quick poll, or a series of one-on-one conversations would be a better use of everyone's time. If this is the case it is best to cancel or not schedule a meeting and allow others to use this time to benefit the project or organization. Once again, by respecting people's time they will be more likely to know when a meeting is called it is important because valuable work will occur.

- *How does this meeting advance the team's or organization's goals?* This final question connects the meeting's purpose with the broader goals of the team or the organization. By aligning the purpose with the overarching goals, the leader can better prioritize topics, frame discussion points, and direct outcomes that move the team or the organization forward. In addition, by focusing on these overarching goals, it provides a criterion for measuring the meeting's success.

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #2: Create Your Roadmap - The Agenda

The importance of an agenda in hybrid meetings transcends the basic functions of outlining the flow of the meeting. The agenda provides all participants, irrespective of their physical location, with a clear understanding of the meeting's scope, purpose, expectations, and goals. The clarity an agenda provides is critical in an environment where the inherent challenges of managing different modes of communication demand a higher degree of organizational and intentionality. An agenda offers a shared reference point that can bridge the virtual gaps between participants, fostering a sense of shared purpose. Additionally, this tool ensures that participants will perceive time being utilized efficiently, encourage discussions that remain on track, and harness the collective intelligence of the team to drive forward meaningful outcomes.


MEETING AGENDA

Date ____/_____/_____
Location:

Time Keeper:	Note-Taker:
GOOD NEWS Names 1. 2.	**Brief Description of the Recognition** 1. _____ 2. _____ _____
Updates - Old Business 1. Project - Name-Time allotted 2. Project - Name-Time allotted 3. Project - Name-Time allotted	**Quick Updates on Previous Tasks or Objectives (Questions to Consider)** • How are you feeling about your progress so far? • What measures of success can you report? • What are the tasks that you need to accomplish this week? • Any issues you are dealing with (parking lot if they take more time)
TO DO'S - New Business Priority #1. Project/Objective/Issue Time allotted Priority #2. Project/Objective/Issue Time allotted Priority #3. Project/Objective/Issue Time allotted	**Prompt Questions to Guide Discussion on the Prioritized Items** • What is the Project/Objective/Issue? • What are the outcomes we are looking to achieve? • What are the next steps to address the Project/Objective/Issue? • What resources are needed to address the Project/Objective/Issue? • In a year from now, if we do not achieve our goal on this Project/Objective/Issue, what most likely went wrong? • How do we address the issue that most likely went wrong up front?
Additional Information Include a reminder here of any activities the participants should engage in prior to coming to the meeting. Do they need to review any documents? Do they need to bring any information/feedback from other stakeholders?	

The creation of a best practice agenda, sent out ahead of time, can truly impact the effectiveness of a meeting. The following are hybrid meeting agenda best practices that leaders should consider when putting together this roadmap for their meeting.

- Include the meeting name, time (both start and end times), place (physical space and link to virtual space).
- Take time to complete the agenda before calling the meeting. Creating an agenda is a great way to know if you should have a meeting. If you are having difficulty finding items to put on the agenda, it is possible you might not need to formally meet with the team.
- Prioritize items on the agenda in order of most important. This will ensure that these items get the most time and that individuals are most alert during these conversations.
- With each item/task posted on the agenda provide a clear and concise description outlining discussion points and expected outcomes.

- Assign realistic time slots to each agenda item. This helps in keeping the meeting on track and ensures that sufficient time is allotted for important discussions.
- Think about incorporating breaks because attention spans can wane faster online, so consider shorter meetings or plan breaks for longer sessions.
- If there are documents to review, issues to research, or specific tasks to complete before the meeting, include these in the agenda with clear instructions and deadlines.
- In the email sending out the agenda it is best practices to encourage collaboration on agenda items. Simply instructing those invited to the meeting to look over the agenda ahead of time and to send along any comments, questions, or updated items that should appear on the agenda.
- It is wise to send the agenda out as early as possible to provide time for individuals to process items and come to the meeting prepared to contribute.

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #3: Define Meeting Roles

Two best practice roles to have at a meeting include a timekeeper and a note taker. While most meetings have these two components, often they are underutilized or used inappropriately. For example, often the leader takes on the role of timekeeper believing they are in the best position to keep the team on task. However, with all the demands on the leader during the meeting, often (with good intentions) based on conversations, questions and bias toward particular topics, the leader does not hold to the agenda. The following is a short list of best practices to get the most out of the timekeeper and notetaker in hybrid meetings to ensure the team maximizes productivity.

Timekeeper

Keeping the meeting on time and being able to address all topics on the agenda is one important element of an effective meeting. No matter the intentions of a leader to do this task, all too often, with competing demands of the meeting they can't focus on time management. It is important that a leader assigns a timekeeper for each meeting (can rotate and is included in the agenda). The roles of the timekeeper are to provide timely warnings as the end of allotted time approaches and signal when it is necessary to move on to the next topic. It is important that leaders empower the timekeeper to be assertive enough to interject and notify the group when time limits are reached, ensuring that discussions remain on track. Additionally, the leaders should provide the necessary tools (stopwatch, clock, or other time management aids) to help the timekeeper perform their duties.

Note Taker

Similar to the timekeeper, the note-taker identifies what needs to be captured (key points, decisions made, action items and assigned responsibilities) and records the content to transcribe for follow up minutes/notes. While this role may be the natural part of someone's role within the group (e.g. Executive Assistant), if it is not, then the role should continue to switch from meeting to meeting. It is really important that particular individuals are not selected time and time again because of a preconceived notion of level of importance or "having nice handwriting." This will lead to certain members of the team feeling (and possibly being) less valued. Often it can help to

have a structured template to take the notes to ensure what needs to be captured. Finally, several of the meeting technologies today have options for a scribe to take notes on the meeting (automated). While this should not be in place of a note-taker, it certainly can help those taking notes to be more thorough. Take time to explore this option for the technology you utilize in your hybrid meetings.

Running the Hybrid Meeting Best Practices

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #4: Prior to Meeting welcome participants and engage in social chat with those who arrive early. Then start the meeting on time!

It is important for those running the meeting to show up prior to the meeting beginning. While it is understandable that leaders are truly busy, actions often speak louder than words. Showing up late to a meeting, or not starting a meeting on time is one of the most common errors a leader makes in communicating the importance of the meeting. While others will have no choice but to forgive the late arrival, it really does send a message on how important their time is. If a leader shows up prior to the meeting it allows them to engage in social chat that can build strong relationships with others. It also allows the leader to start the meeting on time, letting others know that it is important to be at the meeting (on time) and that you value their time. Additionally in hybrid meetings it is important to pay attention to both participants online and face-to-face. This might be one of the few times the online participants get to interact with the leader in an informal setting.

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #5: Start the meeting with "Good News" or a positive statement/praise

The first item on the agenda should be "Good News," or recognition for individuals at the meeting. This simple gesture, which takes very little time, sets the tone for the meeting. This simple act puts everyone in a positive mindset and lets those participating know that the leader values positive feedback. Additionally, it helps to move into more difficult discussions (should they arise) in the future of the meeting.

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #6: Move to Reporting and Updates

While this is not one-way communication between the leader and the participants only (which is better to do in an email) these updates are from the different participants on previous items discussed at a past meeting. The updates should be quick and inform about previous tasks, data on a previous project or any customer/stakeholder issues. Once again, these are just headlines. If it is something that will require more attention, move it down and prioritize it in the "to do" list

of the agenda (also called new business). A very common phrase that leaders utilize to move this down to the "To Do" items or even at a one-on-one meeting is that the team should "park" that idea. This "parking lot' idea allows leaders to let those addressing the issue know it is important but can not take up time from general updates.

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #7: Address Prioritized "To Do" List

This is why you had the meeting and will lead to the objectives or goals of the meeting being satisfied. Due to this, these items should take up the most amount of time on the agenda. Those highest priority items should come first (with the most amount of time allocated), leading to less critical items (in case time runs out on the meeting).

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #8: Thank people for contributions and finish meeting on time.

As important as it is to start the meeting on time, it is equally important to finish the meeting on time. While a leader might perceive that it is ok (especially if there is good discussion happening) to extend the meeting out, a few outcomes happen when this is the case. First, and most importantly, participants feel like you do not respect other obligations. While the leader might have free time, it certainly does not mean that everyone in the meeting has free time. Secondly, there are diminishing returns on investment in a meeting that has gone over time from participants. It is much better to follow up after the meeting with a select group of individuals or schedule another meeting to continue the conversation. Best practices suggest that leaders finish all items or close conversation five minutes prior to the scheduled end time of a meeting. This will allow for the leader to give final thoughts, review action items, and/or ask participants to evaluate how the meeting went (and what can be changed for effectiveness of future meetings).

Post Hybrid Meeting Best Practices

Hybrid Meeting Best Practice #9: Follow up by sending out minutes, action items, and the next agenda.

Once a meeting has concluded, the leader should collect the minutes/notes from the note-taker and follow up with participants. The follow-up, possibly in the form of an email, should include the meeting minutes, action items from the meeting, and an agenda for the next meeting. This follow up meeting communication is also a chance to reinforce key messages from the meeting and recognize the contribution of others. Once you have begun the process of creating the follow up message, and more specifically the agenda for the next meeting, the best practice process begins again.

By implementing these best practices, leaders can ensure that the time both participants and the leader spend in hybrid meetings translates into tangible results, fostering a culture of accountability, and builds stronger relationships.

References

Perlow, L. A., Hadley, C. N., & Eun, E. (2017). Stop the meeting madness: How to free up time for meaningful work. *Harvard Business Review*, *95*(4), 62-69.